

Death Certificates

How the certificate gets completed and filed, how many certified copies your family will actually need, and what each one costs.

SECTION 1

How a Death Certificate Gets Made

Three steps, and we handle the filing for you

Certified copies come from the health department of the county where the death occurred, and none can be issued until the original certificate is complete. That takes three steps, and the whole process usually runs **7 to 10 business days**.

1

The doctor signs

The physician certifies the death and states the cause. Nothing else can move until this signature is in place, and it's the step most often behind a delay.

2

You confirm the vital information with us

The legal name, birth date, parents' names, occupation and the rest. We fill it out together and you confirm it's right before anything is filed. The **Vital Statistics Worksheet** lists everything the state asks for.

3

We file with the county

We submit the completed certificate to the county vital records office and order your certified copies at the same time.

If there's an error on the certificate

The Department of Health in Olympia allows a **one-time free exchange** to correct an error. Plan around the wait, though: corrected certificates can take up to **8 weeks** to come back. It's one more reason to check every name and date carefully with us before filing.

SECTION 2

How Many Copies You'll Need

More than you'd guess, and not all of them need to be certified

There's no limit on how many certified copies you can order. Most families end up using **8 to 12**. The right number for you is the number of institutions on this list that apply to your loved one's affairs, so it's worth sitting down with the list once and counting.

Before you count every line, ask each institution whether they need a **certified copy** or will accept a **photocopy**. Banks, insurers and government agencies almost always require certified. Utility companies often don't. Every photocopy that works is \$25 you don't spend.

It's far easier to order enough upfront, with the original filing, than to go back for more later.

WHERE A DEATH CERTIFICATE MAY BE NEEDED

- **Life insurance** claims, one per policy
- **Property or mortgage**
- **Military benefits**
- **Bank accounts**, one per bank
- **401(k) accounts**
- **Retirement pensions**
- **Medicaid benefits**
- **Motor vehicle licensing** and title transfer
- **Credit cards**
- **Utility bills**: energy, cable, internet, phone
- **Transporting cremated remains** to another state or country

SECTION 3

What They Cost

The state price, and the county add-ons to know about

ITEM	COST
Certified copy of a death certificate, state of Washington	\$25.00 each
Pierce County orders: shipping	\$4.00
Pierce County orders: review fee	\$10.00

Every certified copy in Washington is **\$25.00**. Pierce County adds a \$4.00 shipping charge and a \$10.00 review fee on top of that. Other counties and other states set their own charges, so ask us, or check with that county's health department directly.

You can also order certified copies on your own at any point, straight from the website of the county where the death occurred. You don't have to go through us, and the price is the same either way. We order the first batch with the filing because that's the fastest route, and you can always add more later.

Questions about your certificate order

If you're not sure how many to order or whether an institution needs a certified copy, call me and we'll count through your list together. It takes ten minutes and usually saves money.

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